Eugene Wigner had jaundice. “I was in the infirmary for six weeks. It was a wonderful period, because jaundice doesn’t hurt really,” Wigner recalled. “They fed you on potatoes, beans, and everything boiled in water, and the food was not good. But the rest and the detachment were wonderful.” Wigner shared the news of uranium fission with his visiting friend Leo Szilard, another Hungarian refugee physicist who had realized the enormous possibilities of a nuclear chain reaction years earlier. “Szilard was in Princeton, and he came to visit me every day, and we discussed fission problems and this and that. Well, the theory of Bohr and Wheeler of course occupied us very much.… Szilard came to me one morning and said, ‘Wigner, now I think there will be a chain reaction.’”

Debating what to do next, the two Hungarians enlisted a third: Edward Teller, who had settled in Washington, DC. Over the summer of 1939, this “Hungarian conspiracy” developed a plan to alert the US government to the fact that “Hitler’s success could depend on [nuclear fission],” as Szilard put it. Putting their plan into motion, they recruited a fourth conspirator: Albert Einstein. The Hungarians hoped that a letter from the most famous scientist in the world would get the attention of President Roosevelt. Spending several weekends with Einstein at his vacation house on Long Island, Szilard, with help from Teller and Wigner, crafted a letter to pass along to FDR. The plan worked, to a point: the letter did get FDR’s attention, but he appointed Lyman Briggs, the ineffectual leader of the Bureau of Standards, to head a Uranium Committee. Briggs and his committee did little, and the project stalled for over a year while Hitler occupied Denmark, captured Paris, and relentlessly bombed London.

When the US government finally started to seriously investigate atomic power in the fall of 1941, Wigner met with Arthur Compton, an American physicist who was preparing a report for FDR’s Top Policy Group on the feasibility of developing atomic bombs. “[Wigner] urged me, almost in tears, to help get the atomic program rolling,” wrote Compton. “His lively fear that the Nazis would make the bomb first was the more impressive because from his life in Europe he knew them so well.”

Several months after the attack on Pearl Harbor, the American atomic bomb project was turned over to the military. It was assigned to General Leslie Groves, an administrator with the Army Corps of Engineers. Groves had just completed directing the building of the Pentagon (then the world’s